Sentinels of the Dawn

The Newsletter of the Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration

Monastère Notre Dame des Anges Troyes, France

Christmas 2008 Issue 4

Witnesses for Our Time

"This is a cause of great joy for you, even though you may for a short time have to bear being plagued by all sorts of trials; so that when Jesus Christ is revealed, you will have been tested and proved like gold— only it is more precious than gold, which is corruptible even though it bears testing by fire— and then you will have praise and glory and honor." 1 Peter 1: 6-8

In the past few months we have seen an increasing outbreak of violence against Christians in India. After returning home from a mission on the 16th of August, Fr. Thomas Pandippally was brutally murdered by Hindu extremists. Not long after, new levels of anti-Christian violence broke out as churches were desecrated and reports were given of religious women being raped. Many of our Indian brothers and sisters are at present living in a state of terror and some have even been forced to flee from their homes.

The stark reality of these sufferings hit home when we received news that one of our own Indian monasteries in Mangalore had been attacked. One afternoon a group of Hindu fanatics entered our Sisters' chapel and began to desecrate it. Rocks were thrown at the monstrance, which fell to the ground on the side of the chapel where the Sisters were in prayer at the moment of the attack. Several statues and a crucifix were damaged as well. Unfortunately, one man who was in the chapel at the time was injured as he attempted to stop the intruders.

Sadly enough, the graveness of these persecutions is not being sufficiently exposed to the media. Police, too, are doing very little to stop the violence that continues to affect these Christians who are being persecuted because of their faith. Our thoughts and our fervent prayers rest continually with our Indian brothers and sisters during these times of trial. In times like these we see how we can take our own faith for granted.



Throughout the history of the Church, in lands where the blood of martyrs has been poured out, seeds of faith have been sown and saints have been raised up. Our Holy Father Benedict XVI recently canonized one of these exemplary figures. Saint Alphonsa of the Immaculate Conception, a religious of the Congregation of the Poor Clares, became the first Indian woman to be presented for public veneration on the 12th of October. This saint's heroic virtues of patience, fortitude and perseverance in the midst of suffering remind us that God always gives us the necessary strength to overcome any trial. Seen as another St. Therese of Lisieux, Alphonsa's one desire was to become a saint. On the occasion of receiving the holy habit, she declared that she would accept any suffering, which might console Our Lord in His Passion. Her request was granted. From that time on she experienced excruciating pain in her body and was given little reprieve. Through her sufferings, she chose to be "a victim of reparation and atonement for those who were indifferent or resistant to the grace of God." (*L'Osservatore Romano, October 15, 2008*). At the moment of her death, Alphonsa was not very well known, but soon after she began working powerful miracles and cures. These manifestations were particularly directed to children, who were drawn to this confidante and friend while she was still alive. Even more surprisingly, this saint worked her miracles among non-Catholics. Now devotion to her passes far beyond India, as people from around the world come to Bharananganam to pay homage. Through Saint Alphonsa's powerful intercession, we pray for our persecuted Indian brothers and sisters, that they may be witnesses of Jesus Christ Crucified and lift high the cross, so as to gain an eternal crown in the life to come.



From the Pen of a Pilgrim...

On the afternoon of the 12th of September, Sister Mary Germaine and I boarded a train— destination: Paris. Our excitement was almost uncontainable as we waited for the events of the next 48 hours to unfold. The Poor Clares in Paris had graciously extended an invitation to our community to send two Sisters to stay overnight in their monastery and participate in the Papal Mass on the morning of the 13th. Sister and I felt honored to represent our little community in Troyes as we headed northwest.

After a 1 ½ hour journey by train, changing metros twice, and a short jaunt on foot, we arrived safely at the monastery. Mother Clare Alix and the Sisters welcomed us with open arms. Once inside, we met other Poor Clares from Reims, Nantes and Habourdin. What a blessing to be among these dear Sisters, in whom Franciscan joy was so evident! Fraternal time was spent together, sharing and watching some of the coverage of Our Holy Father's presiding at Vespers in the Cathedral of Notre Dame of Paris and his exhortation to the youth that followed. Early to bed and early to rise…

Before the break of dawn our little flock of Sisters scurried through the streets of Paris in hopes of obtaining a "close" seat for the Mass. A new level of excitement welled up in our hearts as we approached the "Esplanade des Invalides", the location designated for the Papal Mass. Once inside the main gates, we were quickly swallowed up in a large crowd. Forging ahead, or rather resigning ourselves to be pushed along by the thousands of pilgrims in our midst, we reached a point where we could not advance any farther. There, we "settled in" for the next four hours. Once again time seemed to be moving too slowly, until the increased roaring of the crowd indicated that the Vicar of Christ was finally making his way down the path in his popemobile. What a sight to behold— flags waving, cameras clicking, even nuns standing on their chairs to get a better look at the Pope! His presence truly brought out a response and joyful awe in each one of us, as we waited to hear him speak to our hearts. The atmosphere changed from loud acclamations of joy to intense moments of silence as we prepared our hearts to receive the Holy Father's message.

Throughout the course of his homily, two main questions were posed— "What is important in the life of every human being? To what, consequently, do we give priority in our hearts?" (*L'Osservatore Romano, Sept. 17th, 2008)* To one and all, young and old alike, a challenge was presented— an appeal to discover or rediscover God in our journey in life, which demands both reason and faith, so as to shun idols of power, greed and many others that can easily lead us astray. Through this same faith, Our Holy Father encouraged us to give the greatest veneration to the Blessed Sacrament, the real presence of Christ in His Church. Yes, Christ is truly in our midst. "He will help us to purify ourselves from all idols, in order to arrive at the truth of our being, in order to arrive at the truth of His Infinite Being." (*same citation as above*) Seeds of hope and encouragement were planted— our faith was re-affirmed.

A moment in time comes and goes, but the apostolic visit of Pope Benedict XVI will remain vivid in the hearts and minds of the citizens of France for years to come. This historical event for the eldest daughter of the Church indeed enkindled our faith through the witness of the Vicar of Christ, who is the living presence of Jesus in our midst.

-Sr. Faustina Marie







A LESSON TO LEARN

There is a saying that "Rome was not built in a day"! This is to say that some things in life take time, patience and lots of effort. Learning a new language is a very good example. As somewhat "new arrivals" in a foreign country, how quickly we learned that communication with others is a basic necessity for survival. Naturally, one wants to be understood, and likewise, understand others. In the beginning this is not so easy, but with the grace of God all things are possible.



Thanks to the generosity of others, we are making progress in the beautiful French language. Since some of our Sisters have been in France longer than others, we have two study groups dubbed: the "debutants" and the "veterans". For those in the first group, Sister Germaine of the Oblates of Saint Francis de Sales comes to the monastery twice a week. Under her wonderful guidance our Sisters in the beginning stages are expanding their French vocabulary and learning to form sentences and phrases. Training the ear to listen and comprehend are also other areas where they are improving. Thank you, Sister, for your precious time and gracious effort in this mission.

Brother Claude Darreye of the Christian School Brothers works with the "veterans" once a week. His sense of humor keeps us looking on the brighter side of things and our Sisters are learning as many different French expressions as there are cheeses in this beloved land! Of course no task is ever too much for Brother, regardless of the time or day. We are grateful for his self-less example of fraternal charity and his availability.



Recently, Madame Nicole Hany-Longuespé, author of "The Treasure and Relics of the Cathedral of Troyes" as well as conservator of the antiquities and sacred art for the diocese of Troyes, has gladly volunteered her services to the "veterans." Once a week she comes prepared with interesting lessons about the history of Troyes, which often times include slide shows. Our Sisters have this rare opportunity to view snapshots of stain glass windows from the Cathedral and other churches in the diocese, as well as precious and sacred articles contained in the treasury of the Cathedral. At present, the Sisters are learning about some of the first bishops of Troyes, a diocese in which the Catholic faith dates back to the 1st century! What a blessing for us who long to delve into the spiritual wealth of this diocese, in which are found so many powerful saints, magnificent churches and sacred works of art.



May God bless each one of them a hundredfold! May their reward be great for all the ways they share with us the beauty of the language and richness of the history and culture of France.

AVE! AVE! AVE MARIA !

On the great Solemnity of Christ the King, it appeared that the King of Kings and Lord of Lords wanted to give honor to the Queen of Heaven. Thanks to the generosity of a friend and benefactor of the Community, we received a statue of Our Lady of Lourdes for a grotto located in our cloister garden.



After the Mass, Msgr. Savourat, our chaplain, blessed the statue, and Our Lady was carried in procession from the chapel to the garden. The Sisters and the gathered assembly payed her due hommage by singing the Ave Maria of Lourdes. The blessing was a perfect touch to such a grace-filled day, which began under blue, sunny skies only to end with the surprise of snow in the afternoon!



In celebrating the 150th anniversary of the apparitions at Lourdes this year, may Our Lady intercede for each one of us, entrusting all our intentions to her Son, Jesus.

Monastere des Clarisses
26 Rue Mitantier
10000 Troyes
FRANCE

www.clarissesdetroyes.com

At the close of another liturgical year, we take time to look back upon the events of this past year, as always, with thankfulness. For both the joys and the sufferings we experienced, we give thanks. For those loved ones who been called to their Eternal reward, we place them in the merciful Hands of our Heavenly Father; for those whom we have come to know, we praise God for their friendship, their gifts and talents; for those who support us materially and spiritually, we thank God for their fidelity, their faith, their esteem for the contemplative life.

As we prepare to celebrate the birth of Jesus, let us be thankful for the wonderful gift that God has given to us. ***The Word was made flesh and dwelt among us***. Emmanuel— God with us. He came into this world so that we might have life. Through his birth on that holiest of all nights, we share in this new life. With Mary, the Holy Virgin, and good St. Joseph, we approach the holy crib to offer our hearts of love and praise to the Divine Child; with the shepherds, we stand watch, in awe and wonder; with the angels, we sing "Gloria in Excelsis Deo"; and with the Three Wise Men, we offer gifts of prayer and adoration on bended knee. This Christmas you will be remembered in our prayers before the Most Blessed Sacrament, as we adore the newborn Christ, who awaits each of us with open arms. O come, let us adore Him! May He bless you and your loved ones in the New Year.



A Most Blessed Christmas and grace-filled New Year to all!